
SHOLAY**Ramesh Sippy, 1975**

Often credited to director Ramesh Sippy's producer father G. P. Sippy, *Sholay* is a Hindi action-adventure movie, which transported the conventions of the Hollywood Western to India, to create the country's first blockbuster. Set in the rocky terrain of Karnataka in southern India, it tells the story of two small-time villains, Veeru and Jai, who become heroes when they are hired by a retired police officer to help capture the *dacoit* (bandit) Gabbar Singh, who is terrorizing their village. Some critics condemned the movie's glorification of violence, but it was a huge hit at the box office in India, and quotes from the movie ("What's going to happen to you now, Kaalia?") are embedded in Indian culture. It is the defining "masala" movie—a blend of action, drama, comedy, romance, and music.

XALA**Ousmane Sembene, 1975**

Xala is a movie by Senegalese director Ousmane Sembene, adapted from his own novel. "Xala" (pronounced "hala") is the curse of sexual impotence that businessman El Hadji believes has befallen him after his third marriage. As he searches for a cure, El Hadji neglects his business. Finally, a beggar who has haunted his office for years reveals it was he who laid the curse on El Hadji, for ruining his own life years before. El Hadji will only be cured by standing naked while beggars spit on him. The movie is seen as a metaphor for the French-speaking Senegalese

elite following independence, who exploited the poor and became pawns in the colonial game.

ERASERHEAD**David Lynch, 1977**

David Lynch's debut feature was an enigmatic, low-budget movie that became a cult hit. The story focuses on Henry Spencer (Jack Nance), a label printer with a weird shock of hair, whose girlfriend has a reptilian-looking premature baby. But the basic plot is just a hook for an increasing array of unsettling images and scenarios. The movie's title comes from a moment when part of Henry's head is removed and taken to a pencil factory to be made into erasers.

See also: *Blue Velvet* 256–57

DAWN OF THE DEAD**George A. Romero, 1978**

Dawn of the Dead is the classic zombie horror movie, an unrestrained follow-up to Romero's 1968 feature *Night of the Living Dead*. After the US is devastated by an infection that reanimates the dead, four friends escape by helicopter and hole up in a shopping mall, where they have all their needs met but are besieged by the living dead. While the movie is generally regarded as a clever critique of American consumerism, it is also an unashamed gore fest.

DAYS OF HEAVEN**Terrence Malick, 1978**

Days of Heaven is most memorable for its sumptuous Texan landscapes and its captivating score by Ennio

Morricone. The movie begins in 1916 and tells the story of Chicago steelworker Bill (Richard Gere) who, after a bust-up with his boss, flees to Texas with his girlfriend Abby (Brooke Adams) and teenage sister Linda (Linda Manz), who narrates the movie. They work long hours in the fields until, seeing a chance to escape poverty, Bill encourages Abby to marry the farmer, who has apparently just a year to live. However, the farmer lives on, and the story spirals into a tragedy of jealousy and biblical plagues.

APOCALYPSE NOW**Francis Ford Coppola, 1979**

Inspired by Joseph Conrad's 1899 novella *Heart of Darkness*, Coppola's *Apocalypse Now* is set during the Vietnam War, as Captain Willard (Martin Sheen) is ordered to go deep into the jungle and kill Colonel Kurtz (Marlon Brando), a decorated officer who has gone insane and commands his troops as a demigod. The difficulties faced while filming in the Philippines are legendary, but the result was a movie of hallucinatory power, with a relentless sound track that swings from roaring helicopter blades to the pounding rock of *The Doors*.

See also: *The Godfather* 200–05

RAGING BULL**Martin Scorsese, 1980**

Robert De Niro's Jake La Motta is a hungry and desperate boxer who, after finally winning a champion's belt, descends into a world of seedy bribes. He abuses his wife and all his friends, and ends up bloated and overweight. It's a measure of Scorsese's and De Niro's skill that